

PART 1C: PLAYER CHARACTER FACTIONS

by [Justin Alexander](#) – December 5th, 2018



Let's briefly discuss *Chapter 2: Trollskull Alley*. This remix is largely not going to be discussing this chapter of [Waterdeep: Dragon Heist](#) because it is mostly unimpeachable and almost certainly the best part of the published campaign. To briefly review:

- The PCs are awarded with Trollskull Manor, which they can “refurnish, rebuild, rename, and otherwise personalize.”
- The expectation is that they will reopen the tavern on the first floor, and a number of encounters and mechanics are given for doing so.
- During this time, their recent notoriety also results in them being approached by one or more factions who would be interested in having them join up.
- The factions ask the PCs to perform a series of missions for them, spanning from the time the PCs are 2nd level until they are 5th level.

The faction missions, it should be noted, are clearly intended to be interwoven with the ongoing events of what we're referring to as the Grand Game, but this is one place where the campaign kind of glitches because the heavily compressed timeframe of the primary plot doesn't really leave a lot of breathing room for integrating these missions (or running their new tavern for that matter).

This remix should help address this problem simply by virtue of decompressing the events of the Grand Game: Investigating the Faction Outposts (Part 3) and performing the Eye Heists (Part 4) will expand the timeline and give a little more room for integrating the faction missions.

Beyond that, there are only two tweaks I would suggest for *Chapter 2: Trollskull Alley*:

- Add 1-3 additional urban adventures that overlap with setting up the tavern and running the early faction missions.
- Review the [Running the Game: Tavern Time](#) essay here at the Alexandrian and use it to bring Trollskull Tavern to life. (UPDATE: I ended up doing a customized version of this for *Dragon Heist*. You can find it [here](#).)

You might also consider fleshing out the faction missions and putting a little more meat on their bones, but I think you'll largely find that unnecessary: As designed the faction missions will take up perhaps one-quarter or one-third of a session. As such, they'll integrate with everything else that's going on to create a dynamic, multi-faceted session that draws the players ever deeper into the rich life of Waterdeep. If the faction missions expand to take up a full session on their own, some of that effect will be lost.

On the other hand, giving each faction one meaty mission as a diversion or counterpoint to the Grand Game might make for a good change of pace. (That's going to be beyond the scope of this remix, however.)

ALLIES IN THE GRAND GAME

Once the PCs have joined a faction, however, the PCs themselves become a vector by which those factions can become involved with the Grand Game.

The PCs can ask for help. Factions can provide assistance, particularly when it comes to intelligence gathering. If the PCs need help locating a faction outpost or lair, for example, their faction can probably help them with that. Of course, they might ask the PCs to do them a favor (in the form of a faction mission) first.

Have the factions push them for information. "How have you been spending your time?" "We heard you were involved in that fracas at the Gralhund Villa. What was up with that?" "We've noticed you haven't been around a lot lately. We've got a vested interest in you now, and we need to know how to find you."

Intermingle the factions. You can also have a PC's faction become engaged with a faction of the Grand Game from a completely different direction. For example, maybe the Harpers are interested in exotic poisons which were shipped into Waterdeep (and are destined for the Cassalanter's ritual). Or the Order of the Gauntlet might be interested in targeting Xanatharian slavers.

If these factions discover the Grand Game and/or the PCs' role in it, they are likely to bring their own agenda to bear.

Bregan D'Aerthe is, of course, Jarlaxle's faction and their agenda should be obvious. Look at areas of the campaign where Jarlaxle's agents are present and consider simply making the PCs those agents (perhaps even giving them a small force of drow to command).

The **Emerald Enclave** actually has no interest in the Grand Game or Neverember's ill-gotten dragons. They'll assist PCs who have proven loyal to the faction, but, perhaps refreshingly, will make no demands upon them for the Vault or its contents.

Force Grey is allied to the Open Lord. If members of the Grey Hands or Force Grey bring the Grand Game to their attention, the Open Lord will quickly figure out what actually happened to the missing 500,000 gold dragons and she's going to want the money back.

The **Harpers** know that the Cassalanter are actually demon-worshippers and, if they realize the PCs have gotten tangled up with them, will quickly warn them of the fact. The Harpers are more than happy to let the PCs keep the gold (although they will encourage them to "do the right thing" and return the money to the citizens of Waterdeep), but they want the *Stone of Golorr*, which they believe contains vital intelligence that can help them in their struggle with the Abolethic Sovereignty. It should be noted that the Harpers of Waterdeep are riddled with Zhentarim double-agents, and anything the Harpers learn about the PCs and their activities can very easily fall into Manshoon's hands.

The **Lords' Alliance** actually works directly for the Open Lord. If Jalester Silvermane becomes aware of what the PCs have gotten themselves tangled up in, he'll arrange a discreet meeting with Laeral Silverhand as quickly as possible.

The **Order of the Gauntlet** will expect the PCs to tithe at least 25% of the horde.

The non-Manshoonian **Zhentarim** will see an enormous opportunity in the gold: Efforts are under way to reclaim and repair Zhentil Keep, and that money could be used to buy them a seat on the Zhentarim Council that's forming to do so. This could really raise the profile of the local Zhentarim network, and the PCs would basically be buying their way into the local leadership of the Black Network. (Or they could pursue this thread all the way to the ruins of Zhentil Keep if that's their predilection.)

DESIGN NOTE

These interactions serve to tie the material in Chapter 2 more tightly to the wider events of the campaign spine. Using the PCs' factions to demonstrate the wider scope of how the factions involved with the Grand Game are integrated into the life of the city will deepen the scenario, while also providing the opportunity for creative players to find unique vectors for targeting their enemies. Finally, forcing the PCs to make some tough choices between the advantages and obligations of their faction allegiance will make those relationships more meaningful.